

THE BERGEN COUNTY PROPERTY TAX REALITY CHECK

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Find out in 20 minutes whether your assessment is worth challenging.

STEP 1 Run the math (20 minutes)

- Find your assessed value.** It's printed on your property tax bill. Can't find it? Call your town's tax assessor and ask.
 - Get your town's ratio.** Same call. Ask the assessor: "What is this year's equalization ratio for our town?" Write it down.
 - Divide the first number by the second.** That's what the town says your house is worth. Any phone calculator can do it.
- EXAMPLE:** $\$480,000 \div 0.92 = \$521,700$. The town says: worth \$521,700.
- Ask yourself: would it really sell for that?** Look at what homes like yours nearby actually **sold** for. Sold prices only — not Zillow estimates, not asking prices.
 - See if the gap is big enough to win.** Divide the town's number by 1.15 — the law lets the town be up to 15% too high. Compare the answer with your assessed value and keep the **bigger** one. Homes like yours selling for **less than that number**? You may have a case.

EXAMPLE: $\$521,700 \div 1.15 \approx \$454,000$. Keep \$480,000 (bigger). Homes selling under \$480,000 = a case.

STEP 2 Check the record card for factual errors

Wrong square footage · bathroom you don't have · basement listed as finished · garage that no longer exists · incorrect lot size · an addition that was never built. These are the **fastest corrections** and often don't require a hearing. Email your assessor.

STEP 4 Sweep for relief programs you may have missed (do this with your CPA)

Statewide homeowner relief benefit · reimbursement/"freeze"-style program for eligible senior and disabled homeowners · newer state senior relief program · municipal statutory deductions · veteran and disabled-veteran deductions · property tax deduction vs. credit on your NJ return · your current federal SALT position · mortgage escrow audit — is your servicer collecting and remitting the right amount? · added-assessment review after permitted work.

Verify all current rules at the NJ Division of Taxation.

STEP 3 If there's a real gap, move quickly

- ☐ **Call your assessor and get this year's filing deadline in writing.** Revaluation and reassessment towns run on a different date, and missing it costs you a full year
- ☐ **Ask for an informal review before you file anything.** Many assessors will fix a clear error right there, no hearing
- ☐ **Pull 3–5 closed sales** from the past year — same town, similar style, size, age, lot, and condition
- ☐ **Photograph every condition issue:** deferred maintenance, dated kitchen or baths, water intrusion, obsolete layout, unusable lot, highway, rail, or commercial use next door
- ☐ **Order a licensed appraisal** if the dollar amount justifies it; bring in a NJ attorney for anything complex or high-value
- ☐ **Put your case on one page:** assessment, ratio, implied value, comps, and the value you're requesting
- ☐ **File before the deadline and attend the hearing.** Then check that the corrected figure shows up on your next quarterly bill

STEP 5 Know which slice is which

Your bill has three parts — **municipal, school, and county** — controlled by three different bodies. Pull both budgets from your town and district websites, compare year-over-year by line item, and calendar the two budget hearings. **Public comment at the budget hearing is the only point in the year when the number is still movable.**